Particular care shines through in the way the people in his life are described. Dedicated chapters on more important figures act as tributes to those who imprinted on him values like kindness, discipline, sacrifice and courage. With the passage of time, memory runs the risk of distorting truth, but Sankar's clarity of recall and wisdom from hindsight allow him to unfurl the inner workings of the men and women of Bengal with tenderness. Filled with a disarming candour, he cuts through the layers to reveal complex personas that are both formidable and flawed, but loved, respected, even worshipped, nonetheless.

Sankar's professional laurels, including a long stint with Kolkata's power company, the CESC, where he's now Chief Advisor, seem at odds with his literary persona. "Many describe me as a corporate storyteller," he says in *Dear Reader*. "I am amused to hear this. I am the same clerk that I was at twenty..." His humility notwithstanding, Sankar's ability to "draw on daily life to create something interesting", as Sinha describes it, has led to a wide repertoire of bestselling novels, two of which—*Jana Aranya* and *Seemabaddha*—were made into films by Satyajit Ray.

Dear Reader reads like a journal, a time capsule and a behind-the-scenes documentary all in one, but it is, at its core, a confessional, an opportunity to take stock and offer gratitude, apology and accolades to the people that mean the most to him—his audience included. ■

Ishani Nandi

There are some authors whose prose rises off the printed page like a mist. Or a dream. Soon it begins to affect the prose style of the reviewer. Shahidul Zahir is an author of that sort. Or maybe not? It's hard to tell. Maybe it's the style of the translator, V. Ramaswamy. He appears to have done such a painstaking job that even though the words are in English, the fragrance of the writing remains Bengali.

It's hard to be definite about this or about anything else. Because that's how these stories are written. It's as if the author is continually doubting his facts. Barely has he set down a couple of observations, but he erases them in the next sentence. It's like watching the outgoing tide, the way it writes and rewrites the shoreline. Redefining it all the while.

All the sensations, sights, sounds are very particular to the place and people that Zahir writes about, in and around Old Dhaka. It's like travelling within the skin of someone whose language and thoughts are so far outside one's understanding that even in translation, they remain remote. I found myself thinking that being unfamiliar with the life of a *mohalla* in Bangladesh made it difficult for me to follow the events and motivations of the inhabitants. The more I read, the more I felt as if I had wandered into an alternative universe in which I could not trust my senses to guide me... Is that a raven? Or a rock? A treacherous wife? Or a misunderstood daughter-in-law? A fairy-tale? Or a lesson in local politics?

READING SHAHIDUL ZAHIR IS LIKE WATCHING THE TIDE WRITE AND REWRITE THE SHORELINE

Zahir uses uncertainty as a tool to keep the reader constantly wary, while building a world of sly amusements and melancholy speculations. My favourite story concerns magic figs. A street magician seduces the members of his audiences to become addicted to his figs. But really, the magician is Zahir, and each of his stories is a fig of some sort. Unlike the fictional fruit, these tales are not sweet. Yet each one draws the reader in, tempting them to draw closer, to understand more until it's too late to withdraw.

The world described in these stories has a timeless quality, with cows and ants and rice-fields defining the lives of its citizens, rather than TV and foreign travel. The author died young, in 2008, having published only a handful of books. The translator provides a warm and detailed account of how he approached the task of presenting the work of a relatively under-appreciated author to a larger audience. It can't have been easy: the brusque angularity of English clearly does not suit the ambiguity and sinuous double meanings of the original. These tales would make marvellous short films, however. I can already hear the soundtrack: a breathy flute, a parrot's screech and a communal hookah bubbling in the shade of a hot afternoon. ■

Manjula Padmanabhan

BOOKS

HOOKED BY A HOOKAH

The uncertainty that marks Shahidul Zahir's stories makes them at once beguiling and discomfiting

WHY THERE ARE NO NOYONTARA FLOWERS IN AGARGAON COLONY: STORIES
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